

COMPETITIVE DECISION BRIEF

Passionfroot

Creator-led GTM: where discovery ends and execution begins

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GIFT #15

Executive readout

Passionfroot is entering the U.S. while two boundaries around its creator-led GTM stack are moving: creator discovery is becoming more native to LinkedIn, and Passionfroot's own managed-execution layer is scaling beyond software alone.

1

NATIVE DISCOVERY BOUNDARY

LinkedIn launched Creator Marketplace inside Campaign Manager on 10 Jun 2026. It centralizes creator search, audience/performance insights and contact access. The product is still an alpha for select North American brands and creators, and independent reaction is divided.

2

PASSIONFROOT IS ALREADY WIDER THAN ITS DIRECTORY

Zest can discover creators globally, including external creators not yet on Passionfroot, then move outreach and collaboration into the same workflow. That makes the post-discovery operating layer increasingly important to the product's differentiation.

3

MANAGED EXECUTION IS BECOMING A REAL OPERATING LAYER

Managed Plan evidence predates LinkedIn's 2026 launches. Today Amplify is fully managed end-to-end, while a senior deployment role describes a 5-6 person Campaign Manager team overseeing \$2M+/month across 6-8 accounts. LinkedIn is also building hands-on campaign services through BrandWorks.

WHY THIS MATTERS

The low-regret question is not whether LinkedIn replaces Passionfroot. Public evidence does not support that. The question is which parts of the stack Passionfroot should make most legible and defensible as it scales U.S. GTM: discovery, orchestration, AI execution, human deployment - or a deliberately bounded combination.

Finding 01 - Native discovery is now a layer to re-test

LinkedIn has moved B2B creator discovery into the same environment where marketers already buy and amplify LinkedIn media.

PUBLIC STATE	WHAT THE EVIDENCE SHOWS
LINKEDIN - 10 JUN 2026	Creator Marketplace sits inside Campaign Manager. Marketers can search creators by topic/expertise, inspect audience and performance, access contact information, and connect creator content to Thought Leader Ads. [S3]
INDEPENDENT CHECK	Digiday confirms the product is alpha, English-only and limited to select brands/creators in North America. [S4]
PASSIONFROOT CURRENT	Zest supports discovery plus campaign planning, outreach, collaboration and reporting; the current product also supports creators outside Passionfroot. [S1-S2]

EVIDENCE READ

LinkedIn has created a native alternative for one part of the workflow: LinkedIn-specific discovery and contact. That is enough to question whether creator access alone should carry the differentiation burden. It is not evidence that LinkedIn covers Passionfroot's broader operating workflow.

Finding 01 - The guardrail matters as much as the finding

Independent evidence is explicitly split on how much of the real B2B creator problem the marketplace solves.

VIEW	EVIDENCE
NATIVE DISCOVERY COULD MATTER	Natalie Silverstein of Collectively told Digiday a native marketplace could solve a real pain point because B2B creator expertise is fragmented and niche. [S4]
DISCOVERY MAY NOT BE THE HARD PART	Jess Phillips of The Social Standard argued that B2B creators are busy professionals; even direct contact does not make them easy to activate. Digiday leaves open whether the product becomes a partnership engine or mainly a better directory. [S4]
PASSIONFROOT PRODUCT BOUNDARY	Zest reaches internal and external creators and continues into outreach, collaboration and reporting. The Help Center page is dated 25 Jun 2026, but that date is documentation timing - not proof of the feature launch date. [S2]

DECISION READ

As Passionfroot expands in the U.S., should buyer-facing differentiation center on access to creators, or on the operating system after discovery - strategy, outreach, collaboration, payments and measurement?

GUARDRAIL

Do not claim that discovery has been commoditized, that LinkedIn has caused a Passionfroot product change, or that External Creator support launched in response to LinkedIn. The actual launch date of that Passionfroot capability is not established from the reviewed public evidence.

Finding 02 - Managed execution predates the current platform pressure

Passionfroot's human execution layer is not a new reaction to LinkedIn. Public evidence shows managed campaign execution at least by Q2 2025, then a broader and more explicit operating model today.

TIME	OBSERVED PUBLIC STATE	READ
Q2 2025	Gamma says it used Passionfroot's Managed Plan with a dedicated campaign manager, custom strategy, creator selection and full-service campaign management. The reported campaign results are Q2 2025. [S7]	Managed execution existed before LinkedIn Creator Marketplace / BrandWorks.
CURRENT	Amplify is described as fully managed end-to-end: campaign strategy, creator network, outreach, briefing, coordination, payments and performance. Passionfroot says it works with a select number of tech companies. [S6]	Managed execution is now a named offer, not only a service hidden behind platform usage.
CURRENT	Head of Client Deployment describes a 5-6 person Campaign Manager team and \$2M+/month in creator spend across 6-8 accounts. The same job post self-reports 13x YoY growth and profitability. [S8]	The service layer is being operationalized at meaningful company-reported scale.

SOURCE BOUNDARY

The \$2M+/month, 6-8 accounts, 13x growth and profitable statements are company job-post claims, not audited independent facts. They are used as operating signals, not as standalone findings.

Finding 02 - LinkedIn now overlaps with part of that managed job

BrandWorks does not mirror Passionfroot end to end. It does create a partial functional overlap on LinkedIn-specific B2B creator and campaign execution.

PASSIONFROOT	LINKEDIN
Amplify: fully managed launch/fundraise/company-milestone campaigns; strategy, creator activation, outreach, coordination, payments and measurement. [S6]	BrandWorks: hands-on strategy and creative support for LinkedIn campaigns across brand, creative, content and events. It works with brands and agency partners. [S3]
Gamma: dedicated campaign manager and full-service management; the reported Q2 2025 campaign results were run entirely on LinkedIn. [S7]	Reuters: BrandWorks leads Top Voices 360, which pairs advertisers with creators for sponsored content and generated more than \$20M revenue from May 2025-May 2026; named clients include SAP, IBM and ServiceNow. [S9]
Current deployment role: \$2M+/month company-reported spend across 6-8 accounts, with CMO-ready reporting and direct execution for complex programs. [S8]	Reuters says BrandWorks serves customers ranging from SAP to Webflow, so a clean "mega-enterprise only" segment boundary is not established. [S9]

DECISION READ

As Passionfroot scales U.S. managed execution, which human work is a durable paid service and which work should progressively migrate into Zest? The answer changes product boundaries, staffing, margins and the story sold to buyers.

GUARDRAIL

The overlap is partial. Public evidence does not establish that Passionfroot and BrandWorks compete head-to-head for the same accounts, budgets or procurement decisions.

Strategic synthesis - Two boundaries, one positioning problem

The evidence points to a stack that is expanding in both directions: native platforms are absorbing parts of discovery, while Passionfroot is combining AI software with human deployment.

LAYER	PUBLIC EVIDENCE	IMPLICATION
DISCOVERY	LinkedIn now offers native creator search/insights/contact inside Campaign Manager. Passionfroot also discovers creators across its own network and external sources. [S2-S4]	Creator access remains useful, but it may be harder to defend as a standalone category boundary.
ORCHESTRATION	Passionfroot covers campaign setup, outreach, collaboration, payments and reporting in one connected workflow. [S1-S2]	This is the layer most clearly outside LinkedIn Creator Marketplace itself.
AI EXECUTION	Founding GTM says Passionfroot's AI agents are "10x-ing" how creator marketing gets executed; this is a company claim, while product docs show Zest across the campaign workflow. [S2,S10]	The company is betting that more operational work moves into software/agents.
HUMAN DEPLOYMENT	Managed Plan, Amplify and the Client Deployment team show a parallel human service layer. [S6-S8]	The company must decide which human work compounds product value and which human work becomes delivery overhead.

LOW-REGRET POSITIONING TEST

If Passionfroot wants a durable U.S. story, test the value proposition around ownership of the post-discovery operating layer rather than assuming the marketplace itself is the moat. Then separately define where high-touch deployment is a feature of the product, a premium service, or a temporary bridge to automation.

Decision implications

Three questions worth testing before the U.S. expansion narrative hardens.

01

DIFFERENTIATION ARCHITECTURE

Which buyer-facing claims remain durable if LinkedIn continues improving native creator discovery: network access, cross-platform orchestration, workflow data, payments, measurement, or execution speed?

02

HUMAN VS. AGENT BOUNDARY

Which Campaign Manager tasks should remain a premium human service because judgment improves outcomes, and which should become productized Zest workflows to protect margin and scale?

03

U.S. SEGMENT TEST

Do fast-growing tech buyers and larger enterprise marketing teams value the same combination of software plus managed execution, or should Amplify / deployment be packaged differently by segment and channel mix?

PAID DECISION FRONTIER

A paid Competitive Decision Sprint can test these questions against win/loss evidence, current pipeline, buyer objections, campaign economics and internal delivery costs - evidence that is not public and therefore cannot be resolved by this Gift alone.

Evidence and method pointer

This brief uses public evidence only. The appendix separates fact, company self-report, inference and not-established claims.

- LinkedIn Creator Marketplace claims use LinkedIn primary product material plus Digiday for access-stage and external reaction.
- Finding 01 does not infer causality from the June 25 date on Passionfroot Help Center documentation. The actual launch date of External Creator support is not established.
- Managed execution is anchored first in Gamma's Q2 2025 Managed Plan evidence, then in current Amplify and hiring materials.
- Company-reported operating numbers in job posts are labeled as self-report rather than independently verified financial facts.
- HubSpot is used only as evidence that Passionfroot serves an enterprise-scale buyer; its case study does not establish use of Managed Plan or Amplify.
- No claim is made that LinkedIn has displaced Passionfroot, caused a product change, or currently contests the same accounts.

RESEARCH RESULT

The original thesis was narrowed during adversarial review: an early vendor-led challenger hypothesis was dropped; the LinkedIn claim was reduced to bounded native overlap; and the timing language around External Creator support was removed.

Appendix contents and decision frontier

The supporting Evidence Appendix is designed for source-level review without shrinking the executive brief.

APPENDIX INCLUDES	WHY IT IS THERE
Source register	Provenance and source-class boundaries for each claim.
Claim map	Allowed wording for FACT, COMPANY SELF-REPORT, INFERENCE and NOT ESTABLISHED claims.
Finding 01 evidence	LinkedIn native discovery, Passionfroot external creator workflow, timing guardrails and independent counter-evidence.
Finding 02 evidence	Managed Plan chronology, current deployment scale signals, BrandWorks overlap and segment guardrails.
Dropped / constrained claims	No causality claim, no head-to-head budget claim, no HubSpot managed-tier claim.
QA notes	Adversarial checks that materially changed the final wording.

PAID DECISION FRONTIER

Which parts of creator-led GTM should Passionfroot own as software, which should remain managed execution, and which should be left to native channels - when tested against Passionfroot's actual pipeline, margins, win/loss data and customer behavior?